

Hackles Mentors • Four-Hour Training Curriculum

The Hackles Kit

Trust your hackles. Pause • Check • Tell.

FIELD COPY



PLATE I. The six strands, hand-in-inked, in the order the lessons take them.

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TO VERIFY

Status: **DRAFT.** Counselor or social-work review of this training (especially Modules 5 and 6) is required before first use. Mandated-reporter law, screening and policy points are marked [COUNSEL/HR TO CONFIRM] or [VERIFY]. This training does not make anyone a counselor, investigator or legal expert.

At a glance

SPECIMEN LABEL	
WHO	College students who have applied and passed the screening steps in document 02 (training may be held before background checks clear, as long as no mentor meets children until every step is done)
LENGTH	4 hours (240 minutes), with one 15-minute break. Can be split into two evening sessions of 2 hours or run as one Saturday morning
GROUP SIZE	8 to 25. Add a second trainer above 16
TRAINERS	A trained facilitator and a campus counselor or social worker. A school teacher or librarian as a guest is a bonus.
MATERIALS	Slides or whiteboard; printed code of conduct (document 05); role-play cards (Appendix A); First 10 Minutes drill cards (Appendix B); incident forms (document 06); timer; sticky notes; name tags; sign-in sheet (names only, kept by the coordinator); evaluation cards
REQUIRED BEFORE	Any contact with children
PREREQUISITES	Read the Hackles Day Kit overview (30 minutes) and the Disclosure and Incident Guide (kit/05_Teacher_Support)

Mood. Warm, practical and a little playful. Mentors are role models, not experts on everything. Their most important job is to be a calm, kind adult-in-training who knows when to hand off.

Agenda

MIN	MODULE	FOCUS
0 to 30	1. Welcome and the three promises	Why we are here; safe, kind, never scary
30 to 70	2. The Hackles routine and words that help	Pause, Check, Tell; age bands; say this, not that
70 to 110	3. Boundaries and the code of conduct	Never one-to-one; contact, photos, social media, touch
110 to 125	Break	
125 to 175	4. Disclosures and the First 10 Minutes drill	Practice with printed cards
175 to 205	5. Mandatory reporting, school protocols and your role	Who you tell and how
205 to 230	6. Station practice and accessibility	Run a station from the script
230 to 240	7. Sign-off	Code of conduct, questions, evaluation

Rules of the room for trainers

- No real children, cases or schools are discussed. Fictional cards only.
- **No student plays a child who was harmed or a person who causes harm.** In practice rounds a card is read aloud by a "Card Reader" (a trainer or a peer), in the third person. The mentor in practice answers the card.
- Participants can Pass. A counselor is in the room.
- Participants may bring up personal experiences. Say the heads-up at the start (Module 1) and offer a private conversation with the counselor afterward.
- If a participant discloses something about their own life, use the master protocol for adults in the campus-module Facilitator Guide, Section 6.

Module 1. Welcome and the three promises (30 minutes)

Goals. Participants know what the program is, what it is not, and the three promises that govern every moment with children: **safe, kind, never scary.**

Run of show

MIN	ACTIVITY
0 to 5	Welcome, introductions: name, major, one thing you wish a college student had told you when you were ten
5 to 15	What Hackles is and is not (script below)
15 to 25	The three promises and the Mentor Rules overview
25 to 30	Heads-up on privacy and a counselor introduction

Script

"Welcome, and thank you for being here. You said yes to something unusual. Local schools invite us to help children practice a simple habit: notice when something feels off, pause, check, and tell a trusted adult. That habit is called Hackles. Hackles are what rise on the back of your neck when something seems wrong. We teach children to notice that feeling and act on it.

"A few things Hackles is not. It is not a replacement for a school's safeguarding procedures, a counselor, or professional advice. It has not been evaluated in a controlled study, so we never claim it prevents harm. It is not a recruiting event, a showcase for our majors or a place to advertise anything to children. The teacher leads. You support.

"Three promises. Safe: every child is physically and emotionally safe, and an adult from the school is always in the room. Kind: we meet children where they are, we never shame, and a false alarm is welcome. Never scary: we use made-up examples, no graphic detail, and no scary stories. If you are ever tempted to scare a child into paying attention, stop.

"One more point before we go on. Some of what we cover today can bring up real experiences. You can pass on anything and step out any time. [Counselor name] is here and is available afterward. If you tell me or a trainer something personal today, I will tell you first what I can and cannot keep private. [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM]"

Check for understanding. Ask: "What are the three promises?" Collect answers on a board.

Module 2. The Hackles routine and words that help (40 minutes)

Goals. Mentors can lead the four steps, use the age-appropriate language for each band and use warm, non-shaming words.

Run of show

MIN	ACTIVITY
0 to 10	The routine with motions
10 to 20	The Help Ladder and the age bands
20 to 35	Say This, Not That: pair practice
35 to 40	Debrief

Script: the routine

"Hackles up? That is the noticing step. For a child it might be a feeling in the tummy or the back of the neck when a message is too good, too pushy, too secret or too scary. We teach them to put a hand to the back of their neck, and the motion helps them remember. Pause: hand up like a stop sign. Check: eyes like a magnifying glass, asking is it real, who is it from, what do they want. Tell: point to a trusted adult. Let's do the motions together twice.

"The Help Ladder. A friend you trust, then an adult you trust, then a report. If the first person does not help, climb to the next rung. Keep climbing until someone does. We say this because some children tell once and are not believed.

"Age bands. K-2 uses pictures, a puppet or character, and short sentences. Grades 3 to 5 add the idea of fake messages and checking. Grades 6 to 8 add privacy and respect. Grades 9 to 12 are closer to what you have learned yourself: threat modelling, accounts, scams and how to respond to threats. For your event, the teacher tells you the band and you use the script."

Say This, Not That: pair practice (15 minutes)

SAY	INSTEAD OF
"Thank you for telling me."	"Why did you do that?"
"It's not your fault."	"You should have known."
"Let's get [teacher's name]."	"I'll keep this secret."
"A false alarm is fine."	"That's silly."
"I am not sure. Let's ask."	(making something up)

Pairs take turns reading a child's printed line from the card, as a narrator would ("A child says: I clicked on a pop-up and now my game is weird"), and the mentor answers with a Say line. The Card Reader does not play the child. Swap after each card. Use cards 1 to 3 from Appendix A.

Debrief questions. What was hard to say? What do you say when you feel nervous? How do you keep your face calm?

Module 3. Boundaries and the code of conduct (40 minutes)

Goals. Mentors can state and explain each rule in the code of conduct and say what to do in tricky moments.

Run of show

MIN	ACTIVITY
0 to 15	The rules, one by one
15 to 30	Tricky moments: small groups with cards

MIN	ACTIVITY
30 to 40	Photos, recordings and social media; the pledge

The rules (read aloud and discuss)

- 1. Never be alone with a child.** Stay in sight of school staff at all times. Doors stay open or have a window.
- 2. Never one-to-one.** No private conversations, private messages, rides, favors or special attention.
- 3. Never exchange personal contact.** No phone numbers, social handles, emails or apps. If a child asks, say "I can't, but your teacher can help."
- 4. No photos or recordings of children.** Not for fun, not for the club, not for a class.
- 5. No posts about children.** No social media, no stories, no group chats, not even without names.
- 6. Touch.** Follow the school's policy. Offer a wave or high-five. Do not lift, carry or hold a child. If a child hugs you, a side-turn and a "Thanks, I'm glad you are here" works. Let the teacher handle any comfort touching.
- 7. No secrets.** Never promise secrecy, and never ask a child to keep a secret.
- 8. No gifts.** Do not give or accept gifts or money.
- 9. No marketing.** No products, employers, programs, QR codes or stickers to children.
- 10. Defence only.** No demonstrations of attacks on real people or accounts. No live hacking.
- 11. Respect the host.** Follow the school's visitor, behavior and safety rules.
- 12. Tell right away.** If something seems wrong, tell the staff member present and the Station Lead.

Script

"I want you to hear why these rules exist. They protect children, and they protect you. A mentor who is never alone with a child can never be accused of what did not happen. A mentor who never exchanges contact cannot be pulled into a private relationship, however innocent it seems. The rules are the same for everyone, always, even if you are the nicest person in the world and the child is the sweetest. Especially then."

Tricky moments (small groups)

Groups of three discuss each card. A Card Reader reads aloud in the third person. Mentors write the best response, then share. Use the "Boundary cards" in Appendix A (B1 to B6).

Photos and social media (10 minutes)

"At the event you may be proud and want a picture. Do not take one. A school or the college's own staff may take photos with written parental consent under the host's policy. You do not. After the event, you can post about your own experience without children, schools, locations or details that identify them: 'I spent the morning helping a group of kids learn to spot scams, and it made my week.' You do not name the school. Check any post with the coordinator first for the first two events [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM policy]."

Pledge. Everyone says aloud: "I will follow the rules, even when I think nobody will know, and I will tell when something is not right."

Break (15 minutes)

Module 4. Disclosures and the First 10 Minutes drill (50 minutes)

Goals. Mentors know what to do and say when a child tells them something worrying, and can complete the First 10 Minutes drill in order.

Run of show

MIN	ACTIVITY
0 to 10	Why children tell, and what a calm response does
10 to 20	The First 10 Minutes card, line by line
20 to 40	Drill rounds in trios, with the counselor observing
40 to 50	Debrief and questions

Script

"Children often tell a trusted adult only after a long time. They fear being blamed or punished. A calm, warm response from a college student at a station can be the first time a child feels believed. That makes your job simple and important: stay calm, thank them, promise nothing about secrecy, and tell the staff member who is there. Your job is to listen briefly and hand off. You are not an investigator, therapist or police officer."

The First 10 Minutes (mentor version)

MINUTE	DO	DO NOT
0 to 1	Stay calm. Soften your voice. Keep your face friendly and neutral. Get to eye level.	Show shock, disgust or alarm.
1 to 2	Say: "Thank you for telling me. This is not your fault. You are not in trouble."	Say "Why did you...?" or "You should have...".

MINUTE	DO	DO NOT
2 to 4	Listen. Use open prompts only if needed: "Tell me more." "What happened next?"	Ask leading questions. Ask for details or names.
4 to 5	Be honest: "I can't keep this secret, because I want you to get help. I am going to get [teacher's name] right now, and I will stay with you."	Promise secrecy or outcomes.
5 to 7	Walk with the child to the staff member, in the open, or signal the staff member to come over. Stay in sight of other adults.	Take the child to a private place.
7 to 9	Tell the staff member in a low voice, using the child's words. Say only what the child said.	Add your own guesses.
9 to 10	Tell the Station Lead. Ask the staff member what to do next.	Contact the child later.
After	Write down the child's exact words and what you did, using Form A (document 06), within one hour. Do not share it with friends.	Post, text or talk about it.

Drill rounds (20 minutes)

Trios: **Mentor in practice, Card Reader, Observer.** The Card Reader reads the first card in the third person ("A child at your station says quietly..."). The Mentor responds to the narrator as if the child were there. The Observer uses the First 10 Minutes table as a checklist and gives one specific compliment and one suggestion. Rotate after each card so all three play each role. Run cards D1 to D5 from Appendix B, mild to moderate. The counselor circulates.

Rules for the drill.

- Do not role-play severe scenarios. If a participant asks about one, the counselor will talk privately.
- The Card Reader never speaks as a child. The card describes the child's words in the third person.
- No one plays a person who causes harm.
- Stop the drill at any time if someone becomes upset.

Debrief. What felt hard? What do you say when you feel nervous? How will you remember the first line? (Thank you for telling me. It is not your fault.)

Module 5. Mandatory reporting, school protocols and your role (30 minutes)

Goals. Mentors understand that adults often have reporting duties, that the school's protocol governs, and the exact handoff.

Script

"Many states require certain adults, such as teachers, to report suspected child abuse. Some states require all adults to report. Whether a volunteer

college student has a duty depends on the state and the situation [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM; VERIFY state law]. For your event, [COLLEGE NAME] asks every mentor to do one thing that works under any rule: tell the staff member present right away, in the school's words, and tell your Station Lead. That keeps the child and the report in the right hands.

"The school's protocol decides what happens next. The staff member may call the school's designated safeguarding contact, a child protective services hotline or law enforcement. You do not have to decide whether it is abuse. You do not investigate. You do not contact the family. You do not talk about it with other children. You do not post about it.

"What you write. Use Form A in the forms packet. Record the child's exact words, the date, the time, who was there, what you said and who you told. No opinions, no guesses. Hand it to the coordinator within one hour. The coordinator and advisor will check that the school has what it needs."

Reference table (fill in locally)

ITEM	LOCAL DETAIL
Mentor reporting duty in this state	[COUNSEL TO CONFIRM; VERIFY]
School's designated safeguarding contact	[per school]
State child-abuse hotline	[LOCAL; VERIFY]
Childhelp National Child Abuse Hotline	1-800-422-4453 [VERIFIED 2026-10-05 in kit: childhelpline.org]
NCMEC CyberTipline (online exploitation)	report.cybertip.org · 1-800-843-5678 [VERIFIED 2026-10-05 in kit]
Coordinator's phone for the event	[NUMBER]
Campus counseling center	[NAME, PHONE]
988	Call or text 988; chat at 988lifeline.org [VERIFIED 2026-10-05 in kit]

Your role and your limits. You are a calm, kind adult-in-training. You are not a counselor. If a child appears to be in immediate danger, tell the staff member and the Station Lead right away, and call 911 if no one else can.

Looking after yourself. Hearing a child's worry can be heavy. Tell your Station Lead you need a minute. After the event, the coordinator holds a short debrief, and [COUNSELING CENTER] is available to you in confidence [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM].

Module 6. Station practice and accessibility (25 minutes)

Goals. Mentors rehearse a station from the Hackles Day Kit and know the accessibility options.

Run of show

MIN	ACTIVITY
0 to 5	Overview of stations (Hackles Hunt, Tell-Someone Team, Spot the Fishy, Passphrase Studio, Scam Spotters, Kind Clicks Wall)
5 to 20	Pairs rehearse one station. Use the card: materials, key message, accessibility option, disclosure note, stamp
20 to 25	Share and questions

Station rules

- Fictional examples only. Fake passwords only. No real accounts.
- A trained adult, not a student, plays any puppet or character that represents a harm-causing figure.
- Cyber volunteers: defence only. No live demonstrations, no tools run on real systems, no "how an attack works" beyond what the script gives.
- Sensitive-topic stations (sextortion, grooming, body safety) are never run by mentors.

Accessibility notes for mentors

- Offer Pass at every station. No child is required to speak, move or touch.
- Use short sentences. Repeat. Wait.
- Offer pictures, large print and read-aloud for children who want them.
- Do not ask children whether they have a disability. The teacher tells you about any accommodations.
- Avoid loud or flashing materials. Keep a quiet corner.
- Speak to the child, not about the child. If a child uses an interpreter, a communication device or a support person, speak to the child directly.
- Welcome every family. Children in the room may have parents or caregivers of any shape. Avoid assumptions such as "your mom and dad."
- Children who speak another language at home may know more than they can say in English. Speak slowly and use gestures. Use bilingual materials where the school provides them [LOCAL].

Module 7. Sign-off (10 minutes)

- Read and sign the code of conduct (document 05).
- Hand out the Mentor Quick Card (the rules, the First 10 Minutes and the contact list).
- Collect an anonymous feedback slip: "What would help you feel ready?" and "What was unclear?"
- Trainer notes attendance and sign-off (attendance only; no scores).
- Remind mentors that any breach of the code means immediate removal and review.

Sign-off criteria for the trainer

- Can state the three promises and the Never Rules.
 - Completed the First 10 Minutes drill in order at least once.
 - Signed the code of conduct.
 - Asked their questions, or has a plan to ask the coordinator.
-

Appendix A. Role-play practice cards (fictional composites)

CARDS DESCRIBE A SITUATION in the third person. The Card Reader reads it aloud. The mentor responds. Nobody plays the child or anybody who causes harm.

Words-that-help cards (Module 2)

1. A second grader says, "I clicked a pop-up and my game is acting weird. Did I break it?"
2. A fifth grader says, "My friend sent me a link and said do not tell anyone."
3. A seventh grader asks, "What if I already did the thing and I am in trouble?"

Boundary cards (Module 3)

- **B1.** A fourth grader asks, "Can I have your number so I can ask you stuff about hacking?"
- **B2.** A teacher is called to the office and says, "Can you watch them for two minutes? I will be right back." There are eight children in the room.
- **B3.** A parent at the back of the room says, "Can I get a picture of you with my daughter? It would mean so much."
- **B4.** A sixth grader waves from the hall after the event and says, "Follow me online!" and shows a username.

- **B5.** A child gives you a drawing and a small gift from home.
- **B6.** A mentor friend asks you to post a group photo of the event, with children in the background, for the club page.

Facilitator key for boundary cards

CARD	GOOD RESPONSE
B1	"That is nice of you to ask. I can't give my number, but your teacher can help with any questions." Tell the teacher.
B2	Politely say you cannot stay alone with the children, then go with the children to find the teacher, or ask another adult to join. Tell the Station Lead.
B3	"Thank you, I'm so glad you came. The school has rules about photos, so I can't be in one. Please check with the teacher."
B4	"I can't connect online. Your teacher can help with questions." Tell the teacher and the Station Lead.
B5	"Thank you, this is lovely." Show the teacher and follow the school's policy. Do not keep gifts of value.
B6	No. Photos of children are not allowed. Share only your own words, with no children or school. Tell the coordinator.

Appendix B. First 10 Minutes drill cards (fictional; mild to moderate)

THE CARD READER READS aloud in the third person.

- **D1.** A second grader at your station says quietly, "A kid in my game asked me to keep a secret and said they would be my friend."
- **D2.** A fifth grader says, "Somebody sent me a mean picture of me and now everybody laughs."
- **D3.** A sixth grader says, "I think I got a message that was a scam, and I put in my mom's card number."
- **D4.** A ninth grader says, "A person I know online wants me to send a picture and said they would tell my friends if I don't."
- **D5.** A fourth grader says, "At home I'm scared sometimes. Can you tell my teacher not to call my parents?"

Facilitator notes. In D4 and D5 the counselor gives a short model response and then answers questions privately. Do not run them as full rounds if participants are uncomfortable. The key in all cases: thank, no blame, no promise, get the staff member, stay in sight, write it down.

What a good response sounds like (D1). "Thank you for telling me. You did the right thing. You are not in trouble. I can't keep this a secret, because I want to help. Let's go find Ms. [name] together." Then walk, in the open, to the staff member and repeat the child's words.

Appendix C. Trainer checklist

- ☐ Counselor confirmed and present
- ☐ Room set with open sightlines
- ☐ Forms, cards and the Quick Card printed
- ☐ Sign-in and sign-off sheets ready
- ☐ The facilitator read the Disclosure and Incident Guide
- ☐ A fire drill or exit plan briefed
- ☐ Evaluation cards printed (anonymous)
- ☐ Follow-up: coordinator records sign-offs; mentors added to the event roster only after all steps are complete

Hackles has not been evaluated in a controlled study. It is not a substitute for school safeguarding procedures, counseling or professional advice. Mentors are not employees or agents of Competence Collective for safeguarding purposes unless a signed agreement says otherwise [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM].